11+ Preparation Guide

Complete Topic Guide
and Week 1 Practice Pack

Year 4 starter edition: English, Maths, Verbal Reasoning and Non-Verbal Reasoning

How to use this pack

- Part 1 explains the exam and every topic in plain language (for parent and child).
- Part 2 is the Week 1 practice pack: five weekday sessions plus a weekend quiz.
- Part 3 is the Answer Key. **Detach or fold it away** so your son can't see it while working.
- Keep sessions to 20 to 30 minutes. Praise effort, and treat mistakes as useful information.

Part 1: The Topic Guide

1. What is the 11+?

The 11+ is the entrance exam for grammar schools and some independent schools in England. Children usually sit it in September of Year 6, with results arriving in autumn. Content depends on the area and the exam provider, so **check the websites of your target schools** for the exact format.

Provider	Typical content	Notes
GL Assessment	English, Maths, Verbal Reasoning, Non-Verbal Reasoning	Multiple choice or standard answer; separate timed sections
CEM	Verbal (vocabulary heavy), Numerical, Non-Verbal Reasoning	Mixed, fast-paced questions; strong vocabulary matters most
CSSE and school-set papers	Usually English and Maths; sometimes writing and reasoning	Check each school; formats vary

2. Your preparation timeline

When	Focus	Goal
Year 4 (now to Summer 2027)	Foundations: times tables, place value, reading habit, vocabulary, meeting each question type	Confidence and good habits
Year 5 (Sept 2027 to Summer 2028)	Harder content, speed, topic tests, weak spot work	Accuracy at pace
Summer of Year 5 to start of Year 6	Timed papers, exam technique, full mocks	Exam readiness
Early Year 6 (before exam)	Light revision, mock review, rest	Calm and prepared

3. Weekly routine (20 to 30 minutes, five days)

Day	Focus	Day	Focus
Monday	Maths (number)	Friday	Non-Verbal Reasoning
Tuesday	Verbal Reasoning	Saturday	Mixed quiz
Wednesday	Maths (fractions, measures, shape)	Sunday	Rest, free reading, games
Thursday	English	Every day	20 min reading + 5 min times tables

4. Maths

Maths papers test the National Curriculum up to the end of Year 5 and often into Year 6, plus problem solving. The biggest single advantage is **instant recall of times tables**.

Year 4 priorities

- Times tables up to 12 x 12 and the matching division facts
- Place value up to 10,000 and rounding to the nearest 10, 100 and 1,000
- Adding and subtracting 4-digit numbers; multiplying 2 and 3-digit numbers by 1-digit numbers
- Fractions: equivalent fractions, fractions of amounts, adding fractions with the same denominator
- Decimals: tenths and hundredths; money and measures
- Shape: perimeter, area of rectangles, angles, symmetry
- Time: 12 and 24-hour clock, durations
- Simple word problems (one and two steps)

Topics to add in Years 5 and 6

- Long multiplication and short and long division
- Percentages, ratio and proportion
- Simple algebra and missing number problems
- Averages (mean), angles in shapes, area of triangles and parallelograms, volume
- Negative numbers, prime numbers, square and cube numbers, factors and multiples
- Multi-step word problems and reading data from charts and tables

Key facts to know by heart

Square numbers: 1, 4, 9, 16, 25, 36, 49, 64, 81, 100, 121, 144
Prime numbers (to 30): 2, 3, 5, 7, 11, 13, 17, 19, 23, 29
Shape sides: triangle 3, quadrilateral 4, pentagon 5, hexagon 6, heptagon 7, octagon 8
Units: 1 km = 1,000 m; 1 m = 100 cm; 1 kg = 1,000 g; 1 litre = 1,000 ml; 1 hour = 60 min
Cube: 6 faces, 12 edges, 8 corners

Top maths tips

- Read the question twice and underline the numbers and the question being asked.
- Write working down, even for easy sums. It prevents slips.
- Check answers with the opposite operation (for example, check subtraction by adding).
- If stuck for over a minute in a test, skip it, mark it and come back.

5. English

Comprehension

The child reads a passage and answers questions about it. Three question types appear again and again:

- **Retrieval:** find a fact in the text. Look back and copy the key words.
- **Inference:** work out what the text suggests but does not say. Ask: what clues point to this?
- **Language:** explain what a word or phrase makes you imagine (for example a simile or metaphor).

Tip: always answer in a full sentence and refer back to the text using a short quote or a phrase from it.

Grammar and punctuation

Topic	What to know	Example
Word classes	Noun, verb, adjective, adverb, pronoun, preposition, conjunction	The *happy* dog ran *quickly*.
Tenses	Past, present, future; irregular verbs	swim, swam, swum
Apostrophes	Contraction (don't) and possession (the dog's bone)	The boys' coats
Commas	Lists, after fronted adverbials, around extra information	After lunch, we left.
Speech marks	Around spoken words; new speaker, new line	"Come here," said Dad.
Homophones	Same sound, different meaning	their / there / they're

Vocabulary and spelling

Learn 5 to 10 new words a week, with meanings and a sentence of their own. Use the Week 1 word list in Part 2. Regular reading (stories, non-fiction, newspapers like *First News*) is the most powerful vocabulary builder.

Creative writing (only some schools)

- Plan first: beginning, middle, end, with one clear event.
- Show, don't tell. Instead of 'he was scared', describe shaking hands and a racing heart.
- Vary sentence openings and lengths; use a few vivid adjectives, similes and strong verbs.
- Leave 3 minutes to check spelling, capital letters and full stops.

6. Verbal Reasoning

Verbal Reasoning tests how well a child works with words, letters and logic. A wide vocabulary is the foundation.

Question type	How it works	Example
Synonyms	Choose the word closest in meaning	brave = courageous
Antonyms	Choose the opposite	generous / mean
Odd one out	Find the word that doesn't belong	apple, pear, carrot, plum (carrot)
Letter sequences	Continue the pattern using alphabet positions	B, D, F, H, ? (J)
Letter codes	Apply a rule to change letters	CAT to DBU: each letter moves forward one
Word ladders	Change one letter at a time to make a new word	CAT, COT, COG, DOG
Anagrams	Rearrange letters to make a word using a clue	LISTEN to SILENT
Analogies	Find the relationship, then apply it	Hot is to cold as up is to down
Hidden words	A word hides across the end of one word and the start of the next	'cheap ear' hides 'pea' across the gap

Tips

- Write out the alphabet with numbers (A=1 to Z=26) and keep it beside you when practising codes.
- Learn the common prefixes (un-, dis-, re-, pre-) and suffixes (-ful, -less, -tion). They unlock many words.
- Play word games: Scrabble Junior, Boggle, Wordle, crosswords for kids.

7. Non-Verbal Reasoning

Questions use shapes and patterns rather than words. They test spotting rules, so a calm, step-by-step approach works best.

Question type	What to look for
Sequences	Look at what changes each step: size, shade, number, position, direction
Odd one out	Check each shape for sides, shading, size, symmetry and position
Rotations	Quarter turn = 90 degrees, half turn = 180, three-quarter turn = 270. Clockwise or anticlockwise?
Reflections	Imagine folding along the mirror line. Left and right swap, distances stay equal
Matrices and grids	Rules often work across rows or down columns
Cubes and nets	Know that a cube has 6 faces; picture folding the net
Counting shapes	Count systematically: small first, then combined shapes

Tip: say the rule out loud: 'Each step, the black dot moves one corner clockwise.' Then test it on every option.

8. Exam technique (for all papers)

- **Read the instruction carefully.** Many errors come from answering the wrong question.
- **Time:** aim for roughly one minute per multiple-choice question. Skip and return rather than getting stuck.
- **Eliminate:** on multiple choice, cross out options that are clearly wrong first.
- **Always answer.** There is usually no penalty for guessing.
- **Check:** use any spare time to re-do 2 or 3 questions from scratch.
- **Mindset:** getting questions wrong in practice is exactly how children improve.

9. Marking and progress

After each session, mark together and sort mistakes into three types: **careless slip**, **didn't know**, or **didn't understand the question**. Spend the next session on the 'didn't know' topics. Use the tracker below.

Day	Subject	Score	Time taken	Mistakes to revisit
Mon	Maths (number)	/14		
Tue	Verbal Reasoning	/10		
Wed	Maths (fractions, measures)	/14		
Thu	English	/12		
Fri	Non-Verbal Reasoning	/11		
Weekend	Mixed quiz	/10		

Score guide: 80% or more means ready to move on. 60 to 79% means good, revisit the missed topics. Below 60% means repeat the topic with easier questions first. Don't worry, this is completely normal at the start.

Part 2: Week 1 Practice Pack

Pencil and paper for working out. No calculators. Use a timer to build good habits, but never rush a young child; accuracy first.

Week 1 Vocabulary Words

Word	Meaning	Word	Meaning
abundant	plentiful, more than enough	peculiar	strange or unusual
cautious	careful to avoid danger	ordinary	normal, nothing special
reluctant	unwilling, not keen	delighted	very pleased
fragile	easily broken	vivid	bright, clear and strong
generous	happy to give or share	hesitate	pause before doing something

Challenge: write one sentence for each word during the week.

Day 1 (Mon): Maths: Number

20 mins | 14 marks

1.	6 x 9 = ?	_____
2.	8 x 8 = ?	_____
3.	11 x 7 = ?	_____
4.	72 ÷ 8 = ?	_____
5.	96 ÷ 12 = ?	_____
6.	What is the value of the digit 7 in 3,974?	_____
7.	Write 'six thousand and fifteen' in figures.	_____
8.	Round 4,763 to the nearest hundred.	_____
9.	Put in order, smallest first: 3,405 3,045 3,540 3,450	_____
10.	358 + 276 = ?	_____
11.	704 – 289 = ?	_____
12.	A school has 9 classes with 28 children in each. How many children are there altogether?	_____
13.	What is the next number? 4, 9, 14, 19, ?	_____
14.	1,000 – 457 = ?	_____

Day 2 (Tue): Verbal Reasoning

15 mins | 10 marks

1.	Which word means the same as *brave*? timid / courageous / quiet / clever	_____
2.	Which word is the opposite of *generous*? kind / mean / rich / careful	_____
3.	Find the odd one out: Paris, London, Rome, Spain, Madrid	_____
4.	Continue the sequence: B, D, F, H, ?	_____
5.	Hot is to cold as up is to ?	_____
6.	Change CAT into DOG, changing one letter at a time to make a real word each time: CAT, ?, ?, DOG	_____
7.	If A=1, B=2, C=3 and so on, what is the value of D + E?	_____
8.	In a code, CAT is written DBU (each letter moves one place forward in the alphabet). How is DOG written?	_____
9.	Rearrange the letters of LISTEN to make a word meaning 'not making any sound'.	_____
10.	Which word means 'to look at something very carefully'? ignore / examine / forget / hide	_____

Bonus: Write a sentence using the word *cautious*.

Day 3 (Wed): Maths: Fractions, Measures and Shape

20 mins | 14 marks

1.	What is 1/2 of 36?	_____
2.	What is 3/4 of 24?	_____
3.	What is 2/5 of 30?	_____
4.	Which is larger: 3/8 or 5/8?	_____
5.	1/4 + 2/4 = ?	_____
6.	Write 0.5 as a fraction.	_____
7.	What is the area of a rectangle that is 7 cm long and 5 cm wide? (give units)	_____
8.	What is the perimeter of a square with sides of 6 cm?	_____
9.	How many minutes are there in 2 and a half hours?	_____
10.	A film starts at 2:45 pm and lasts 1 hour 50 minutes. What time does it end?	_____
11.	3.5 + 2.7 = ?	_____
12.	How many grams are there in 2.5 kg?	_____
13.	5 apples cost £2.20. How much does 1 apple cost?	_____
14.	Mia has 45 stickers and gives 1/5 of them to a friend. How many stickers does she have left?	_____

Day 4 (Thu): English

20 mins | 12 marks

Read the passage.

Every morning, Tom woke before the sun. He tiptoed past his sleeping sister and slipped out into the cold garden, where frost glittered on the grass like tiny diamonds. His rabbit, Biscuit, was waiting by the hutch, nose twitching. Tom smiled. This quiet hour, just the two of them, was the best part of his day.

1. What time of day does the story take place? _____

2. Why did Tom tiptoe past his sister? _____

3. What does the phrase 'glittered on the grass like tiny diamonds' tell you about the frost? _____

4. What is the name of the language technique used in 'like tiny diamonds'? _____

5. Find one adjective from the passage that describes the garden. _____

6. Why was this hour Tom's favourite part of the day? _____

7. Which word is the verb? *The children played football in the park.* _____

8. Choose the correct word: (Their / There / They're) going to the park later. _____

9. Add the missing punctuation: where are you going asked mum _____

10. Write the plural of *child* and the plural of *mouse*. _____

11. Choose the correct sentence: (a) I seen the film. (b) I saw the film. _____

12. Write the past tense of the verb *swim*. _____

Day 5 (Fri): Non-Verbal Reasoning

15 mins | 11 marks

Tip: draw each question on scrap paper if it helps.

1.	Circle, square, triangle, circle, square, triangle, circle, ? What comes next?	_____
2.	Number of sides: triangle (3), square (4), pentagon (5), hexagon (6), ? What comes next, and how many sides does it have?	_____
3.	A black square has 1 stripe, then 2 stripes, then 3 stripes. How many stripes in the next square?	_____
4.	An arrow points up. It is turned a half turn (180 degrees). Which way does it point now?	_____
5.	An arrow points right. It is turned a quarter turn anticlockwise. Which way does it point now?	_____
6.	An arrow points left. It is reflected in a vertical mirror line. Which way does the reflection point?	_____
7.	Find the odd one out: square, rectangle, rhombus, circle	_____
8.	A big square is split into 4 equal small squares (a 2 x 2 grid). How many squares of any size can you find altogether?	_____
9.	Shapes alternate in size: big, small, big, small, big, ? What comes next?	_____
10.	A dot starts in the top-left corner of a square. Each step it moves one corner clockwise. Where is the dot after 3 steps?	_____
11.	How many faces does a cube have?	_____

Weekend: Mixed Quiz

15 mins | 10 marks

1.	9 x 7 = ?	_____
2.	150 ÷ 5 = ?	_____
3.	Which word means the same as *enormous*? tiny / huge / quick / calm	_____
4.	What is the next number? 3, 6, 12, 24, ?	_____
5.	Write the plural of *box*.	_____
6.	Which of these numbers is a multiple of 6? 14, 18, 20, 25	_____
7.	? – 36 = 49. What is the missing number?	_____
8.	How many sides does an octagon have?	_____
9.	Book is to library as painting is to ?	_____
10.	Which words need capital letters? *we visited london in august*	_____

Weekend challenge (optional): Read for 20 minutes and then tell someone, in your own words, what happened. Pick three new words you did not know and look them up.

Part 3: Answer Key (parent copy)

Detach or fold away before your son starts. For any question with more than one valid answer, accept any correct one.

Day 1 (Mon): Maths, Number

1. 54
2. 64
3. 77
4. 9
5. 8
6. 70 (seventy)
7. 6,015
8. 4,800
9. 3,045; 3,405; 3,450; 3,540
10. 634
11. 415
12. 252 (28 x 9)
13. 24 (add 5 each time)
14. 543

Day 2 (Tue): Verbal Reasoning

1. courageous
2. mean
3. Spain (the others are cities)
4. J (skips one letter each time)
5. down
6. CAT, COT, COG, DOG (any valid path is fine)
7. 9 (4 + 5)
8. EPH
9. SILENT
10. examine

Day 3 (Wed): Maths, Fractions, Measures and Shape

1. 18
2. 18
3. 12 (30 ÷ 5 = 6, then 6 x 2)
4. 5/8
5. 3/4
6. 1/2
7. 35 sq cm
8. 24 cm
9. 150 minutes
10. 4:35 pm
11. 6.2
12. 2,500 g
13. 44p (£2.20 ÷ 5)
14. 36 (1/5 of 45 = 9; 45 – 9 = 36)

Day 4 (Thu): English

1. Early morning, before sunrise.
2. So he would not wake his sister.
3. That the frost sparkled or shone brightly, like jewels.
4. A simile.
5. cold
6. Because it was quiet and he had time alone with his rabbit.
7. played
8. They're
9. "Where are you going?" asked Mum.
10. children; mice
11. (b) I saw the film.
12. swam

Day 5 (Fri): Non-Verbal Reasoning

1. square
2. heptagon (7 sides)
3. 4 stripes
4. down
5. up
6. right
7. circle (the others have four straight sides)
8. 5 (4 small squares + 1 large square)
9. small
10. bottom-left (TL to TR, then BR, then BL)
11. 6

Weekend: Mixed Quiz

1. 63
2. 30
3. huge
4. 48 (doubling each time)
5. boxes
6. 18
7. 85 (49 + 36)
8. 8
9. gallery (or museum)
10. We, London, August

Well done on finishing Week 1! Add up the scores in the tracker, spot which topics need another look, and come back for the Week 2 pack.